

What are Opioids and Morphine?

- Opioids are medications prescribed to control pain, breathlessness and cough
- They come in different formulations such as liquid, tablets, patches and injections.
- Commonly used opioids: dihydrocodeine, tramadol, morphine, fentanyl and oxycodone
- Morphine is the gold standard in treating cancer pain
- Oral Morphine starts working quickly and achieve maximum effect after 1 hour (oral) and effects wear off after about 4 hours.



Common Fears about Opioids

Does opioids speed up death?

- ✓ Opioids, if used correctly, do not shorten your life span.
- ✓ Research has found that palliative patients receiving morphine lived longer due to optimized comfort and improve quality of life.



Will the effects wear off over time? Does it mean I will need more opioids in the future?

- ✓ The pain-relief effects of opioids do not wear off over time. The right dose of opioids is the dose that relieves the pain or breathlessness with minimal or tolerable side effects.
- ✓ If your pain gets worse due to disease progression, you may need a higher dose of opioids. There is no maximum dose that can be taken.
- ✓ This also means, if your pain gets better due to intervention or treatment, your doctor will reduce the dose.



Will taking opioids lead to addiction?

- ✓ Opioids, if used as instructed by your medical team, will not result in addiction.



Will opioids mask my pain and condition?

- ✓ Good pain control does not mask your condition.
- ✓ Besides pain, there are other symptoms and investigations that are more reliable in assessing your condition.



Should I only take opioids when I can't stand the pain anymore?

- ✓ Some people think that pain is an inevitable part of illness and will wait until their pain reaches an intolerable level before doing something about it.
- ✓ In fact, pain easier to control if managed sooner rather than later.



Does taking opioids means death is approaching?

- ✓ No, this is not true. opioids is widely used to control severe pain, not only by those who are very ill but also those who can still lead everyday life.
- ✓ Treatment with opioids may be necessary to allow you to go about your daily activities comfortably and enjoy a good quality of life.



Common Side Effects

❖ Side effects can be treated

☐ Constipation
Opioids are usually given with laxatives to prevent or relieve constipation.

☐ Dry mouth
Sip water or suck on ice chips throughout the day.
Use oral spray to keep mouth moisture.
suck on candy or sour food.

☐ Nausea and vomiting (temporary)
Take your doses after a meal.

☐ Drowsiness/dizziness (temporary)
Do not drive and do not use tools or machines.



How to take opioids

- ✓ Do not exceed the dose prescribed by your doctor.
- ✓ Do not take a double dose to makeup for a missed dose.
- ✓ Additional doses of opioids can be taken in between the fixed timings if you have sudden pain (breakthrough pain).
- ✓ Remember to wait at least 1 hour from your last dose to take an additional dose.
- ✓ Record the number of additional doses you have taken for the day and inform your doctor at the next visit.

